GIVE A TALK! 2026 · VOL. 4 · MUKOGAWA WOMEN'S UNIVERSITY

Presenting Your Findings

Explaining numbers, graphs, and technical information to an audience, in English

Dr. Brandon L. Kramer · Saturday, October 24, 2026 · 2:00–4:00 p.m.

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Slides

brandonlkramer.github.io/
mukogawa_presentFindings_2026

PRACTICE INTRODUCTIONS · EVERYONE

Who are we?

1	**Name**	"I'm ___ from the ___ department / office."
2	**Your work**	"I research ___." / "I work with data on ___."
3	**One goal**	"I'd like to get better at explaining ___."

About 30 seconds each.

TODAY'S GOAL

Don't just tell people what the data say. Help them see what to notice and why it matters.

Describe

What does the data show?

Interpret

What might it mean?

So what?

Why does it matter to this audience?

2:12
1 · Basic statistical information

2:35
2 · Explaining charts and graphs

3:20
3 · Explaining technical information

3:40
Your 90-second mini-presentation

PRACTICE COMPARE TWO EXPLANATIONS

Both are accurate. Which is easier to follow?

VERSION A

"Group A had a mean score of 73.4, Group B had 68.2, and the standard deviations were 9.2 and 11.4, respectively."

VERSION B

"Group A scored about five points higher than Group B. However, scores varied quite a bit within both groups."

- Why is B easier to follow?
- What does A contain that a technical audience might still need?
- Is the difference in the **phrasing**, the **selection**, or both?

KEY IDEA

Start with the message, not the numbers

1	**Message**	What should the audience notice?
2	**Evidence**	The numbers that support that message.
3	**Detail**	More precise values, only if this audience needs them.

FROM THE FIELD

Don't read all the numbers. Focus on the important points, and leave the numbers on the screen for those who want the detail.

PRACTICE OPTIONAL OPENING · MESSAGE FIRST

LIBRARY SURVEY · ILLUSTRATIVE DATA

Students surveyed	200
Satisfied	62%
Neutral	20%
Not satisfied	18%
Satisfied last year	70%

With a partner

Message: one sentence. What should the audience notice?

Evidence: one sentence, with the numbers that support it.

"Satisfaction with the library has dropped. This year, 62% of the 200 students we asked were satisfied, down from 70% last year."

Useful ways to describe numbers

AVERAGES

The average score was 72.

On average, participants scored...

PROPORTIONS

Approximately 60% of respondents...

Just over half of the participants...

Just under one third...

COMPARISONS

Compared with Group B, Group A scored...

The difference was relatively small.

CHANGE

Participation increased from 40% to 55%.

The number fell sharply to...

CAUTION

The results suggest that...

SAYING IT ALOUD

54.2 fifty-four point two

115,146 about a hundred and fifteen thousand

PRACTICE PART 1 · NUMBER DICTATION

Read the numbers. Your partner writes them down.

ROUND 1 · PARTNER B FACES AWAY

15 · 50 · 13% · 2.5

1,487 · 115,146

0.65% · 3.87

ROUND 2 · PARTNER A FACES AWAY

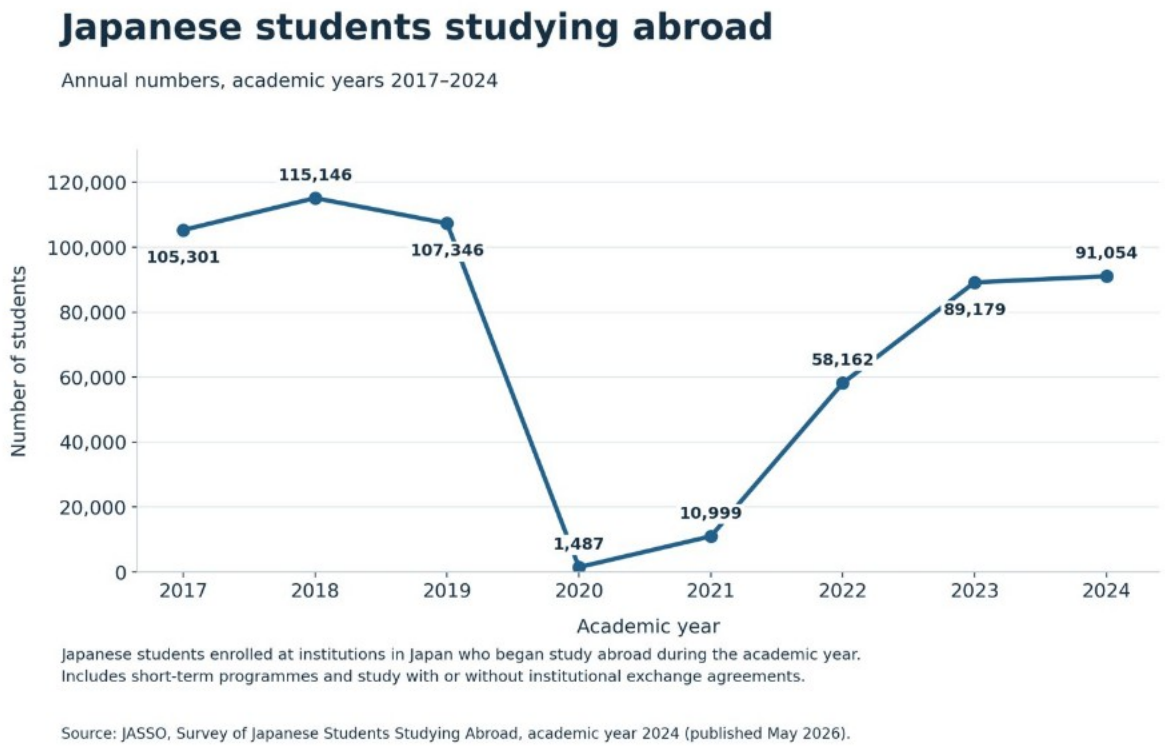
30 · 13 · 18% · 4.25

9,329 · 105,301

1/3 · 26 points

Then check together. Which numbers were hard to hear?

PRACTICE PART 1 · PAIR PRACTICE · SAY THE NUMBERS



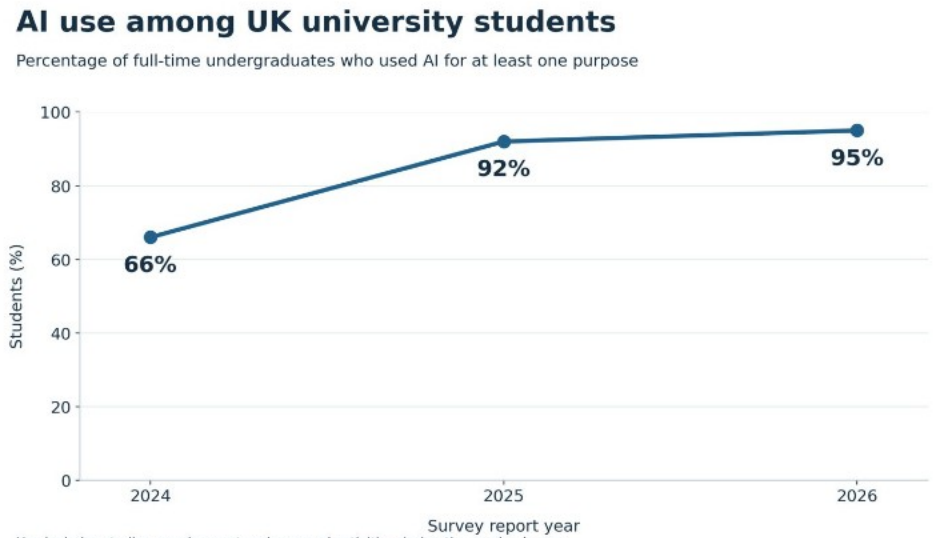
Say three sentences

Before 2020, about _____ students studied abroad each year.

In 2020, the number **fell sharply to** _____.

By 2024, it had **recovered to** just over _____.

Round the numbers when you speak.



66% → 92%

A **26-percentage-point** increase

92 − 66 = 26

An increase of **about 39%**

26 ÷ 66 ≈ 0.39

Both are true. Say which one you mean.

PRACTICE PART 1 · SAY IT TWO WAYS

Describe each change in points, then in percent

CHANGE	PERCENTAGE POINTS	PERCENT
40% → 50%	rose by 10 points	rose by 25%
20% → 30%	rose by 10 points	rose by 50%
80% → 60%	fell by 20 points	fell by 25%
5% → 10%	rose by 5 points	doubled (rose by 100%)

Which version would you use in a presentation? Why?

Always give the denominator

"13 of our students entered the University of Tokyo!"

A typical cram school advertisement. Out of how many?

13 out of **40** students

33%

13 out of **2,000** students

0.65%

FROM THE FIELD

Give percentages, so the audience has some perspective on what the numbers mean. And say how many people the numbers are based on: "1,054 respondents".

PRACTICE PART 1 · PAIR TASK · SAY IT MORE NATURALLY

Rewrite each statement, then say it aloud

ORIGINAL	A MORE NATURAL VERSION
"The participants of 54.2 percent are answering yes."	"Just over half of the participants answered yes."
"The mean of satisfaction score was 3.87 in 5-point scale."	"On average, satisfaction was just under 4 out of 5."
"Group A is 71.6 and Group B is 68.9 for the score."	"Group A scored about three points higher than Group B."
"312 people from 1,040 people did respond."	"About three in ten people responded: 312 out of 1,040."
"First-year students are 400 people, and 25 of them have joined the new program."	"25 of our 400 first-year students, about 6%, joined the new program."

PRACTICE OPTIONAL PART 1 · YOUR OWN NUMBER

Say one number from your own work

1	**The number**	"___ out of ___ ..."
2	**Perspective**	"...that's about ___%."
3	**So what?**	"In plain terms, this means..."

Example: "About 120 out of 900 students, roughly 13%, used the counseling service last year. So what? Most students never use it, even though it's free."

Four moves, then "So what?"

1

Introduce

"This graph shows..."

2

Orient

"The horizontal axis shows..."
"Each line is..."

3

Highlight

"Look at... The main pattern is..."

4

Interpret

"This suggests that..."

5

So what?

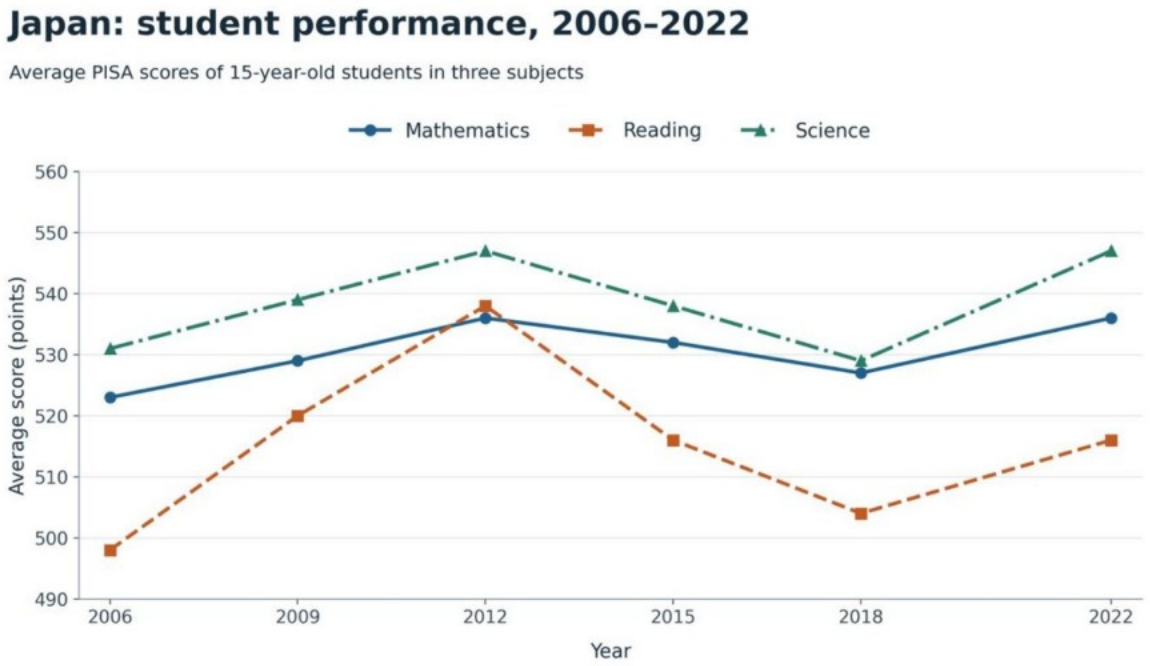
"In plain terms, this means..."

IELTS TASK 1

Overview, key features, comparisons. Stops after describing.

A PRESENTATION

Also tells the audience where to look and why it matters.

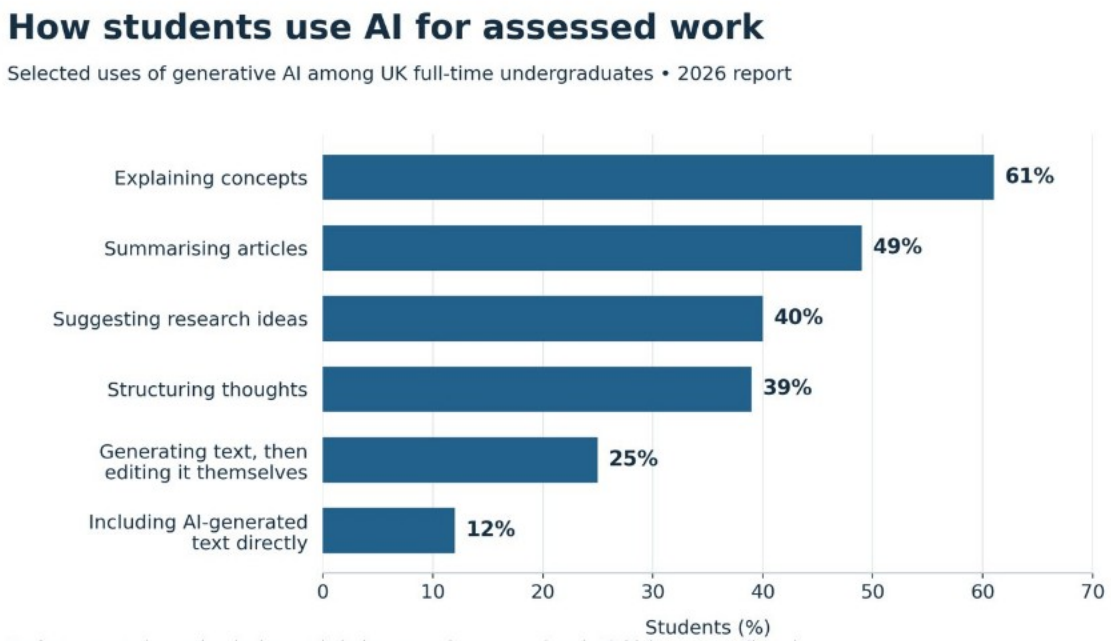


Written "Reading showed the greatest fluctuation, increasing from 498 points to a peak of 538 before dropping to 504 in 2018 and recovering to 516."

Highlight "Look at the orange dashed line. That's reading. It went up and down much more than the other two subjects."

Caution "Note that the axis starts at 490, so these changes look bigger than they are."

So what? "In plain terms, Japan's scores dropped for a few years, but by 2022 they had mostly recovered."



In pairs, 45 seconds each

1. Introduce
2. Orient
3. Highlight
4. Interpret
5. So what?

Partner: ask "So what?" if they forget.

Guide the audience's eyes

FROM THE FIELD

Tell people where to look on a graph.

FROM THE FIELD

Don't make slides too busy.

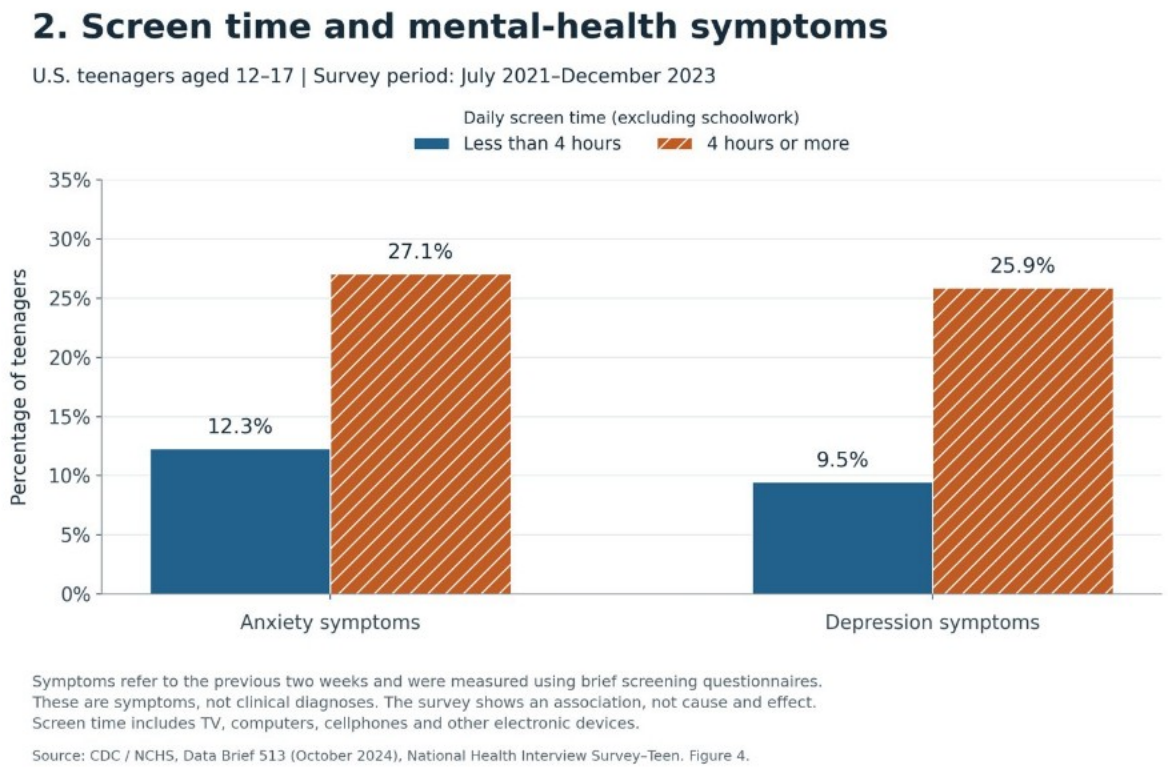
FROM THE FIELD

If presenting in English, try not to read.

Pointing phrases

- "Look at the line at the top..."
- "On the right-hand side, you can see..."
- "The orange bars show..."
- "Notice the sharp drop in 2020."
- "Compare these two bars."

PRACTICE OPTIONAL PART 2 · POINT IT OUT



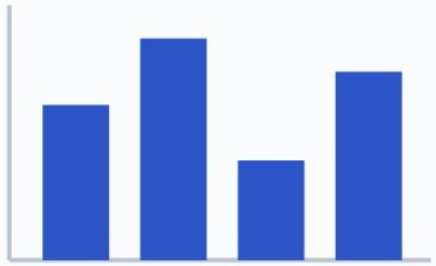
Partner A gives directions

> "Look at the orange bar on the left."

> "Compare the two blue bars."

Partner B points to it and says the number. Three directions each, then swap.

Which chart for which data?



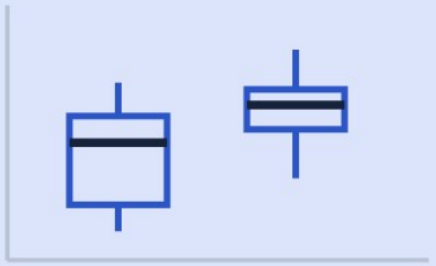
Bar chart
Counts and percentages



Line graph
Change over time



Scatterplot
Relationship between two measures



Boxplot
Scores of groups: the distribution

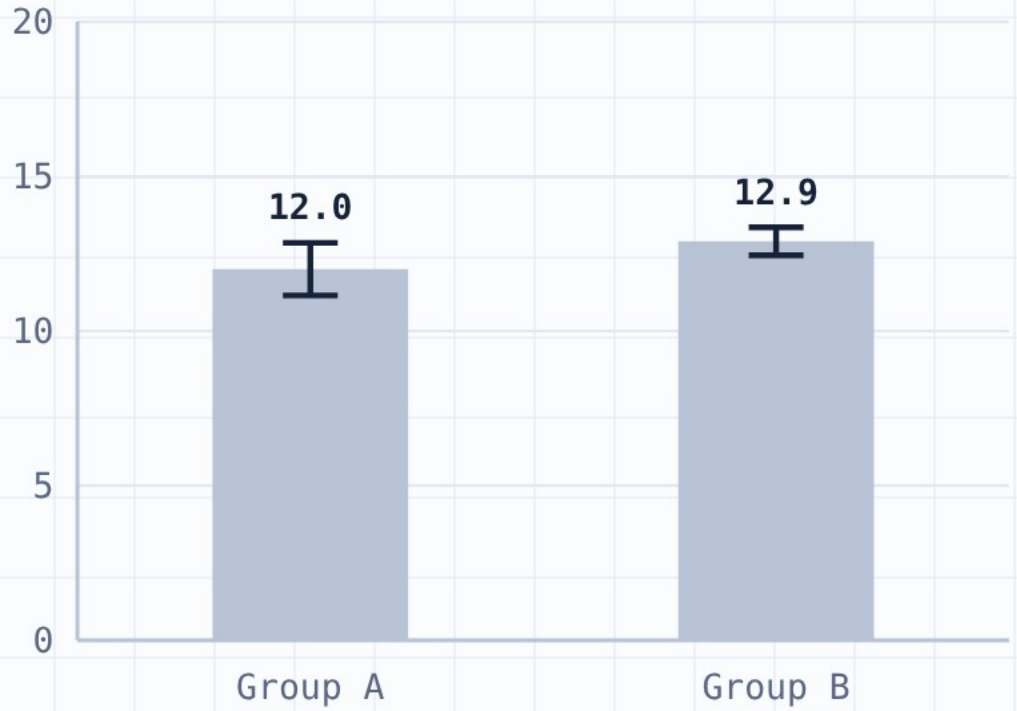
Most of the charts you've seen today are bar and line charts of percentages and counts. That's a good use. Averages of scores need something else.

PRACTICE PART 2 · WHICH CHART WOULD YOU USE?

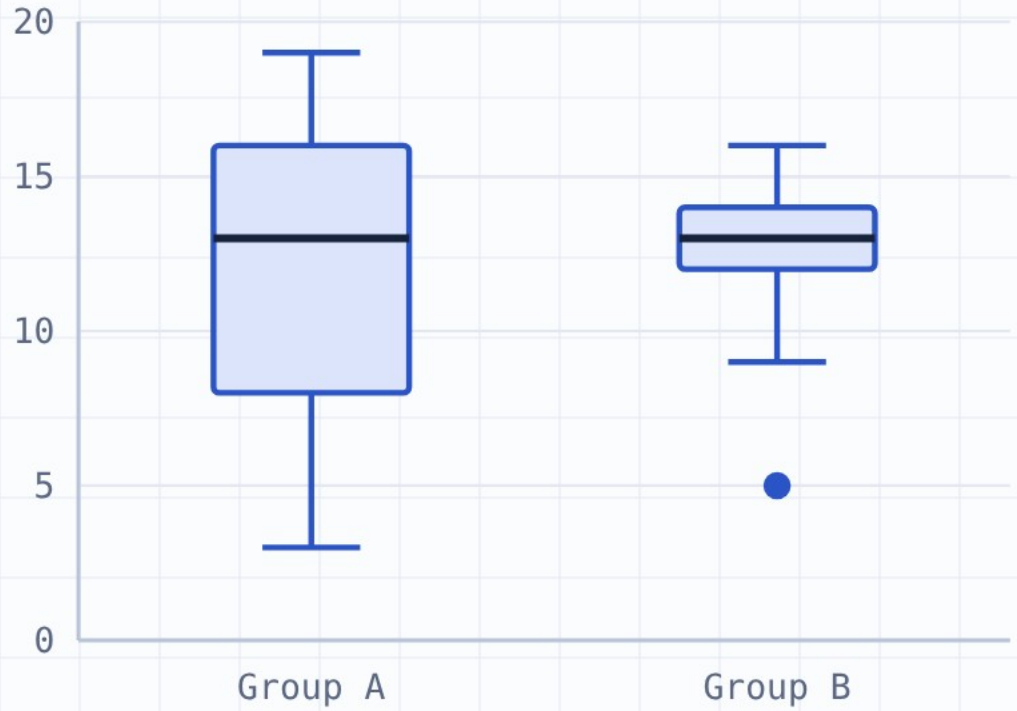
Choose a chart, and say why

DATA	CHART
The number of students in each faculty	Bar chart: counts
Enrollment from 2015 to 2025	Line graph: change over time
Speaking test scores of three classes	Boxplot: the distribution of scores
Hours of study and TOEIC scores for 50 students	Scatterplot: a relationship
Data from your own work	?

> "I'd use a ___ because it shows ___."

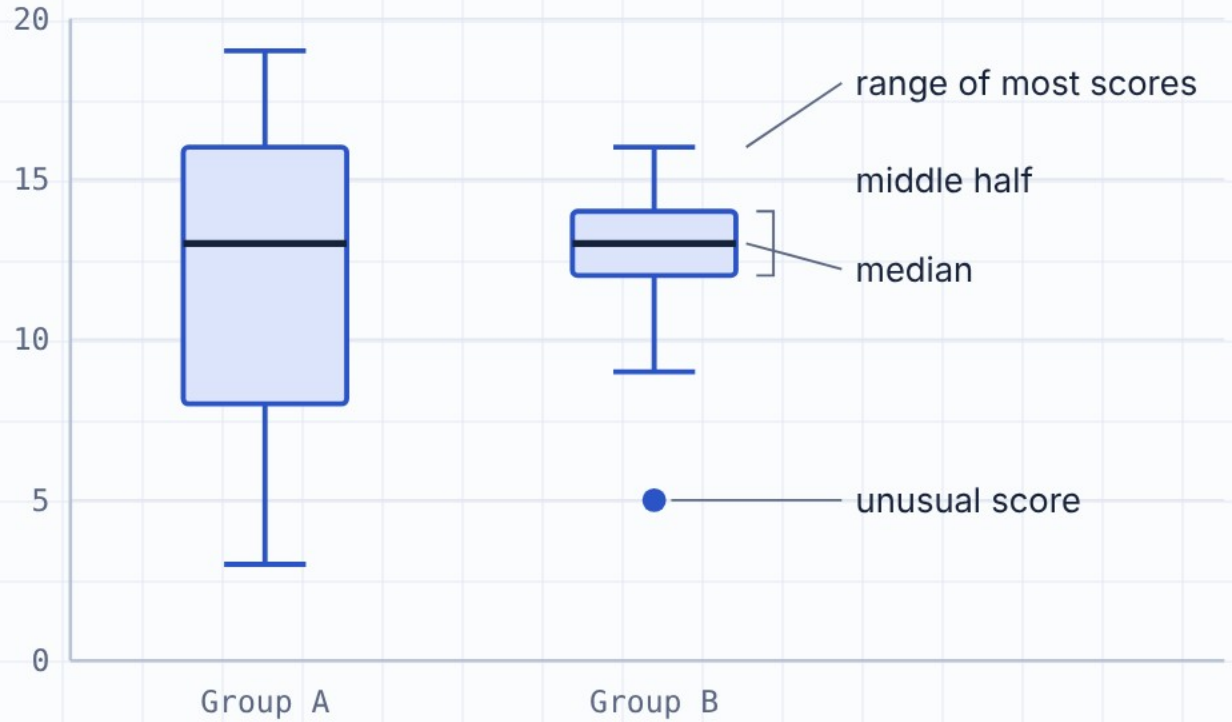


Bar + error bar The groups look almost the same.



Boxplot Group A's scores are far more spread out.

> **FROM THE FIELD**
>
> Avoid vertical bar charts with error bars on top. Use charts that show the distribution. A standard boxplot is best: no extra layers, no bright colors.



"The line in the box is the **median**, the middle score."

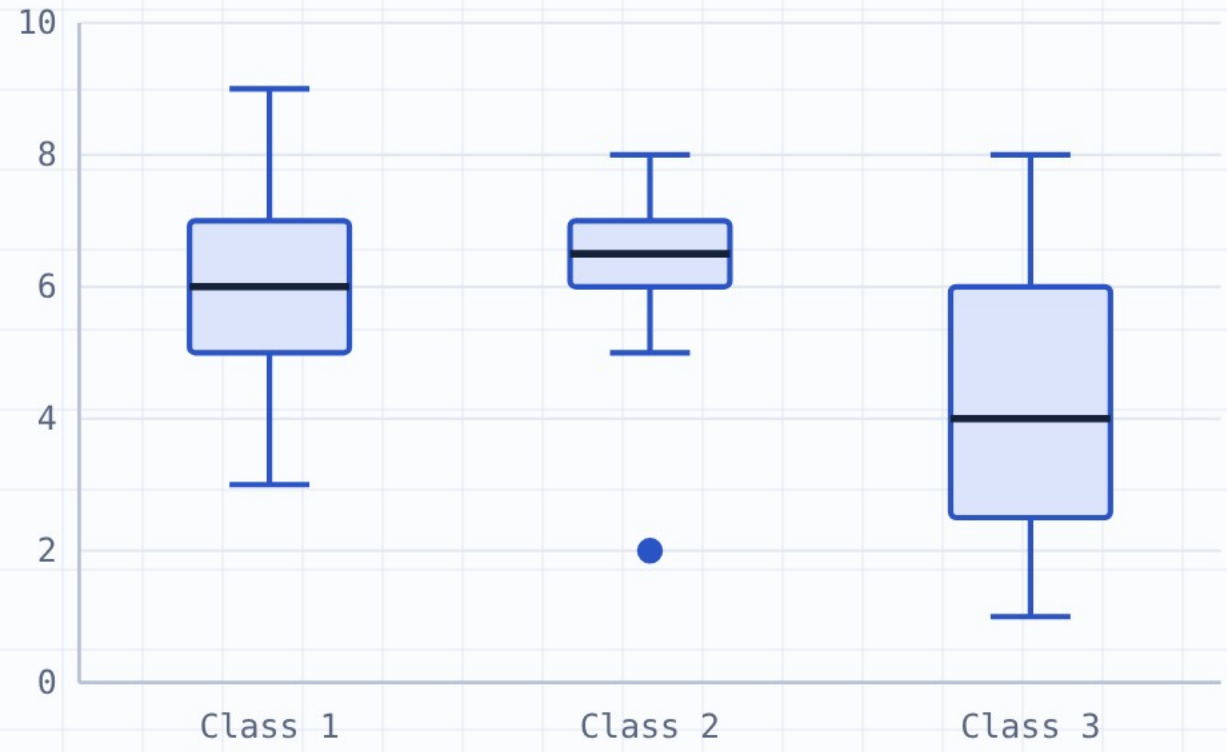
"The box shows the **middle half** of the students."

"The lines show the **range** of most scores."

"The dot is an **unusual score**."

"Scores in Group A were **more spread out**."

PRACTICE PART 2 · DESCRIBE THE BOXPLOTS



Illustrative data · Speaking test, score out of 10

Three sentences + so what

Which class had the **highest median**?

Which class was **most spread out**?

Anything **unusual**?

"Class 2 had the highest middle score, about 6.5 out of 10, and its scores were the most consistent, apart from one unusual low score. Class 3 had the lowest median and the widest spread. So what? Class 3 probably needs the most support."

PRACTICE PRACTICE 1 · GRAPH DETECTIVE

Can your partner get the main point without seeing the graph?

Speaker

Choose a practice chart. Explain it for about **one minute**, using the four moves.

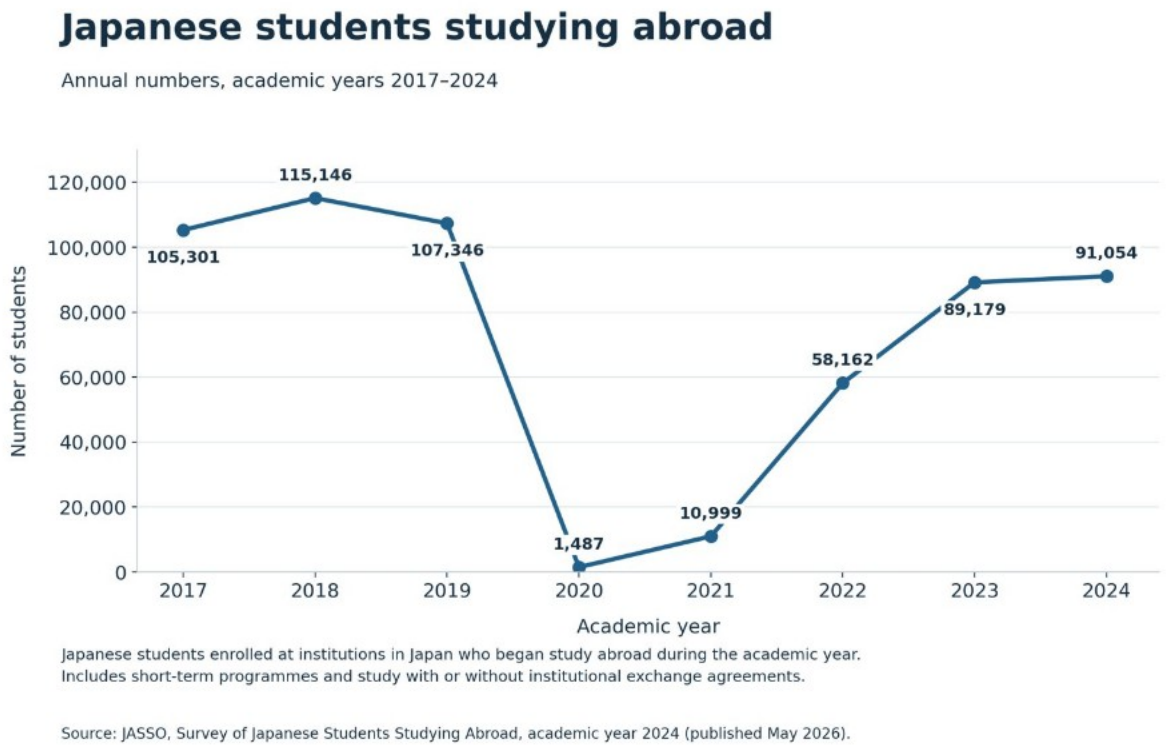
Listener

Don't look at the chart. Then summarize: "So the main point is..."

Then ask: **"So what?"**

Feedback: Did they tell you where to look? Did they read numbers, or explain them? Was anything confusing?

PRACTICE OPTIONAL PART 2 · SPIN IT



Team Success

Make study abroad sound like a success story.

Team Crisis

Make it sound like a crisis.

Every sentence must be true. You may choose the years, the numbers, and the verbs.

Honest: *"Study abroad collapsed in 2020 and has mostly recovered, to about 91,000 in 2024. That's still below the 2018 peak of about 115,000."*

BREAK

15:00

Start timer Reset

Back at 3:20

Simplify the language, not the meaning

TECHNICAL

"A statistically significant interaction was observed between instructional condition and time, indicating differential developmental trajectories."

ACCESSIBLE

"The two groups changed differently over time. In other words, the difference between the groups depended on when they were tested."

Careful: "the **effect** of the teaching method" would claim a cause the study may not support.



Illustrative teaching data (chart D)

Define, rephrase, exemplify

1

Define

"By *retention*, I mean how much people remember later."

2

Rephrase

"In other words, the two groups changed differently."

3

Exemplify

"For example, imagine a student who studies new words on Monday and is tested a month later."

Your listener's three questions: **"What does that mean?"** · **"Can you give me an example?"** · **"So what?"**

Adapted from Ken Bain, *What the Best College Teachers Do* (2004)

PRACTICE PART 3 · EXPLAIN IT TWICE

Say it for researchers, then for everyone else

FOR RESEARCHERS	FOR A GENERAL AUDIENCE
"Participants in the treatment condition demonstrated significantly greater gains in productive vocabulary knowledge."	"Students who had the new lessons improved more in the words they could actually use."
"Inter-rater reliability was high (κ = .85)."	"Two teachers scored the essays separately, and they mostly agreed."
"The score distribution was positively skewed."	"Most students got low scores; only a few got very high ones."
"The response rate was 38%, so non-response bias is possible."	"Only about four in ten people answered, so the results may not represent everyone."

PRACTICE PART 3 · ACTIVITY · EXPLAIN IT OUTSIDE YOUR FIELD

Choose one and explain it

"The survey response rate was 38%."

"There was a weak positive correlation between sleep and exam scores."

"The difference was significant, t(58) = 5.90."

A phrase from your own work

Listener: keep asking

> **"What does that mean?"**

> **"Can you give me an example?"**

> **"So what?"**

Don't paste the whole statistics table

Independent Samples Test

	Levene's Test		t-test for Equality of Means						
	F	Sig.	t	df	Sig. (2-tailed)	Mean Diff.	Std. Error Diff.	95% CI Lower	Upper
Equal variances assumed	.021	.886	5.898	58	.000	3.000	.50868	1.98176	4.01824
Equal variances not assumed			5.898	57.98	.000	3.000	.50868	1.98174	4.01826

Illustrative output

"The reading group scored about three points higher on the 20-item test, `t(58) = 5.90`."

FROM THE FIELD

Don't copy and paste every table from SPSS or JASP. Summarize it briefly in the text instead.

Keep it small, and point to one thing

GROUP	N	MEAN	SD
Extensive reading	30	**14.1**	1.95
Comparison	30	**11.1**	1.99

Illustrative data · Vocabulary test, out of 20

- Only the columns your audience needs
- One decimal place is usually enough
- Highlight the numbers you will talk about
- "Look at the mean column..."
- Give the **n**: the denominator again

PRACTICE OPTIONAL PART 3 · TURN THE TABLE INTO A SENTENCE

TEST	N	MEAN	SD
Before the course	45	8.2	2.1
After the course	45	11.5	2.4
One month later	45	10.6	2.6

Illustrative data · Vocabulary test, out of 20

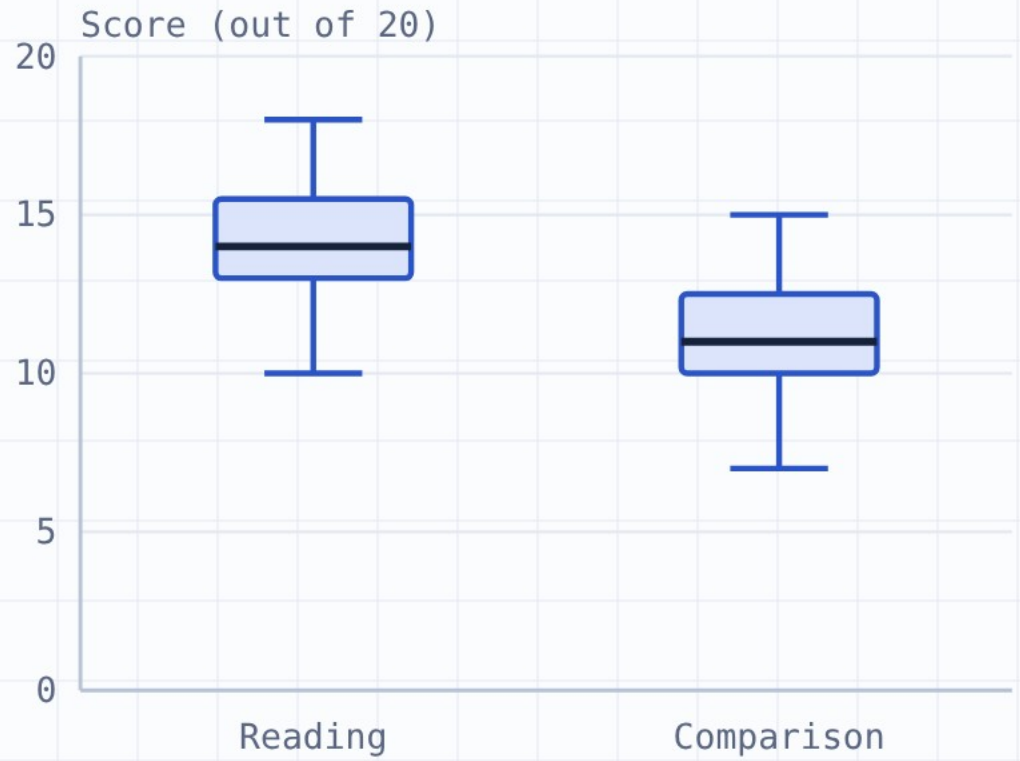
Where to look: "Look at the ___ column."

One sentence: the main finding.

So what? In plain terms.

"Look at the mean column. Scores rose by about three points after the course, and most of that gain was still there a month later. So what? Students remembered most of what they learned."

"Significant" is not the same as "important"



The difference is statistically significant. But what is it in **practical terms**?

> "In practical terms, that's about **three more words out of twenty**."

> "For a teacher, this means..."

> **FROM THE FIELD**
> Don't overemphasize "it's significant". Many vocabulary studies report a significant difference of about 3 points on a 20-item test.

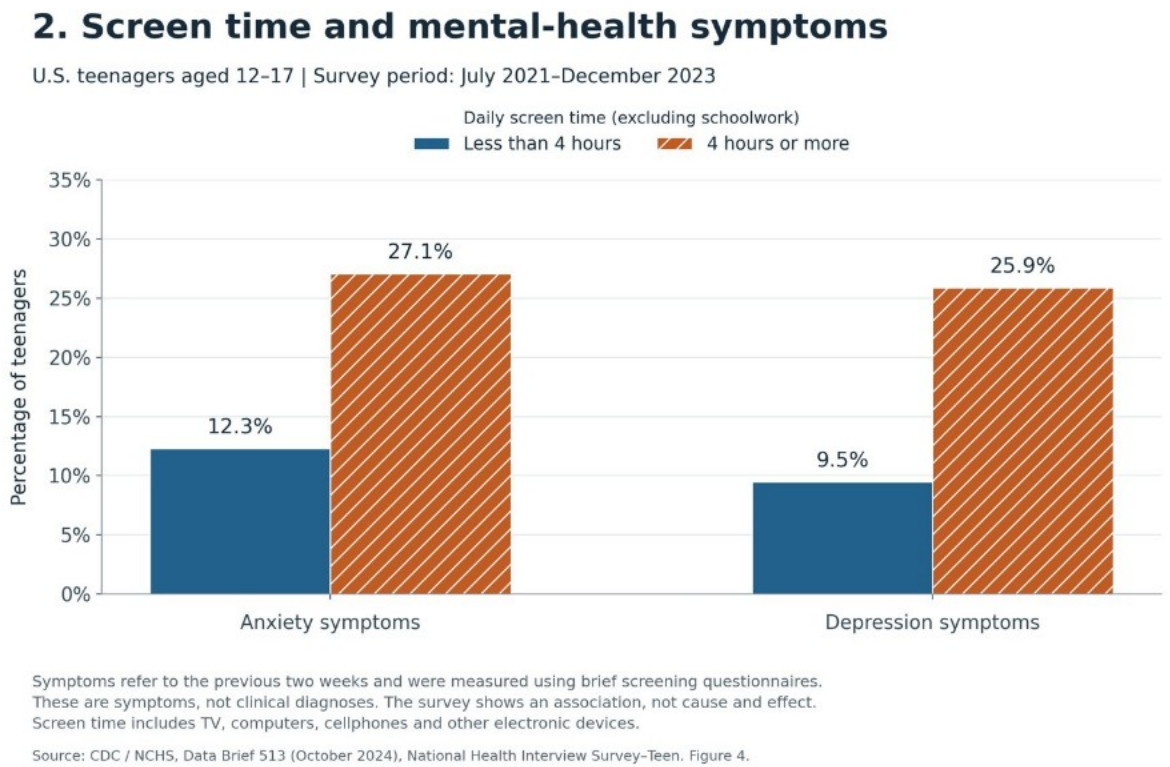
PRACTICE OPTIONAL PART 3 · BIG OR SMALL?

What does it mean in practical terms?

FINDING	IN PRACTICAL TERMS
"Group A scored 2 points higher on a 50-item test, p < .05."	"About 4% of the test. Statistically significant, but a small difference."
"Attendance rose from 82% to 85%."	"3 points: in a class of 30, about one more student each lesson."
"App users studied 12 minutes more per week."	"Less than two minutes a day."

> "In practical terms, that's about..." · "For a teacher / a student, this means..."

PRACTICE OPTIONAL PART 3 · FIND THE MISLEADING CONCLUSION



Which conclusions does the chart support?

A "Teens with 4+ hours of screen time were more than twice as likely to report anxiety symptoms."

Supported: 27.1% vs. 12.3%.

B "Screen time causes anxiety and depression."

Not supported: an association, not cause.

C "About a quarter of U.S. teens have depression."

Not supported: 25.9% is only the 4+ hours group, and these are symptoms, not diagnoses.

A framework you can reuse

1	**"We wanted to investigate..."**	Purpose
2	**"This figure shows..."**	Introduce, orient, where to look
3	**"The most important finding is..."**	Highlight, with the denominator
4	**"One possible explanation is..."**	Interpret, with caution
5	**"So what? The key takeaway is..."**	In plain language

PRACTICE PRACTICE 2 · IN PAIRS OR GROUPS OF THREE

Prepare, present, respond

2 min

Prepare

Choose a practice chart or a result from your own work.

90 sec each

Present

All pairs at the same time. Try not to read.

1 min each

Respond

Main finding? Where to look? Was there a "so what"?

It's fine to say: "We can't determine the reason from this chart alone."

Three final takeaways

1

Lead with the message

Tell the audience what to notice, and where to look.

2

Use numbers selectively

Keep them accurate, and always give the denominator.

3

Answer "So what?"

In the plainest language you can.

Before: "Group A had a mean score of 73.4, Group B had 68.2…"

After: "Group A scored about five points higher than Group B."

Before you present

- Is my slide too busy?
- Can I present without reading?
- Do I tell people where to look?
- Do I focus on the important numbers, and leave the rest on screen?
- Did I give the denominator and a percentage?
- Averages of scores: a boxplot, not bars with error bars?
- A standard boxplot, without extra layers or bright colors?
- "Significant" explained in practical terms?
- A short summary, not a pasted software table?
- Does every statistics-heavy slide end with a "so what"?

Thank you

Questions, comments, or a chart you'd like feedback on? Get in touch.

Dr. Brandon L. Kramer
Kwansei Gakuin University

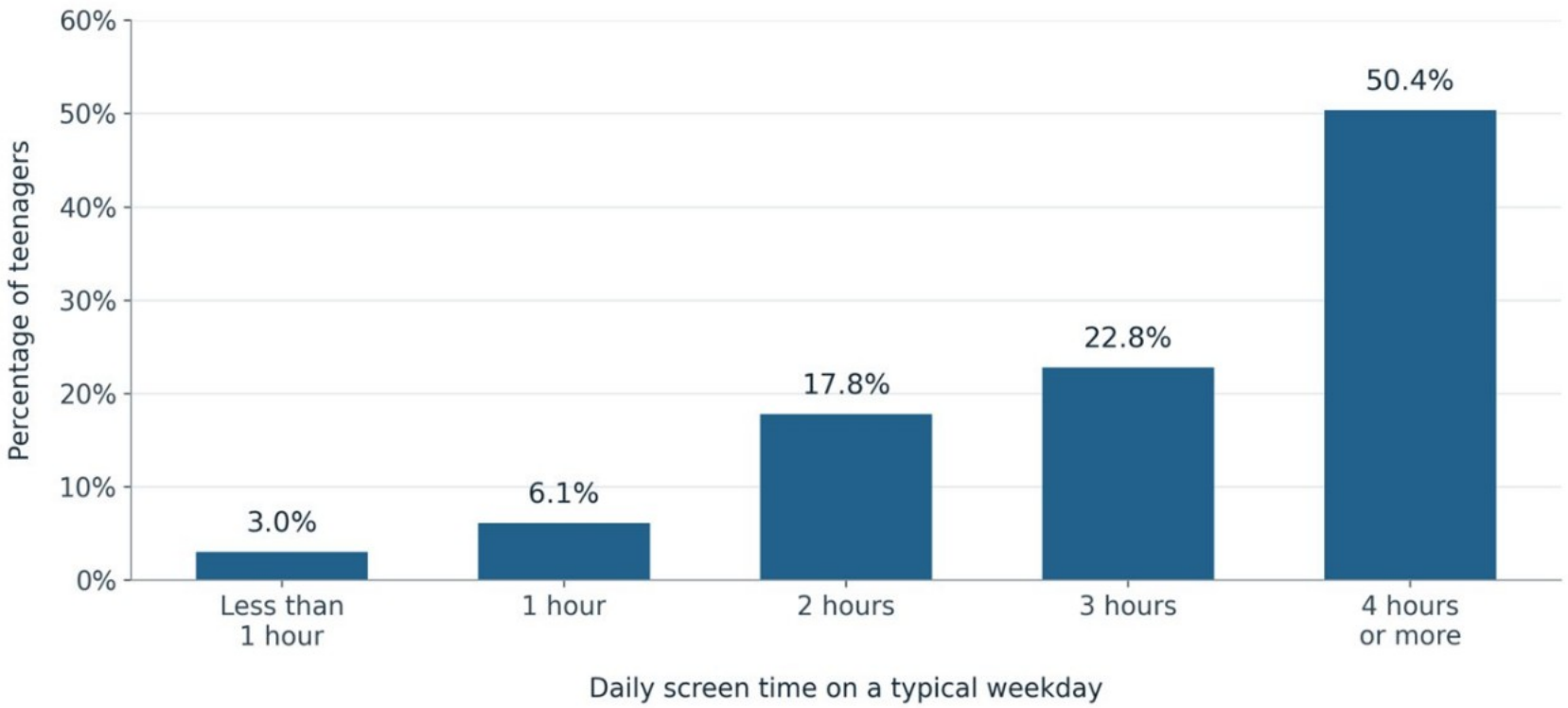
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Slides

brandonlkramer.github.io/mukogawa_presentFindings_2026

1. How much screen time do teenagers have?

U.S. teenagers aged 12–17 | Survey period: July 2021–December 2023



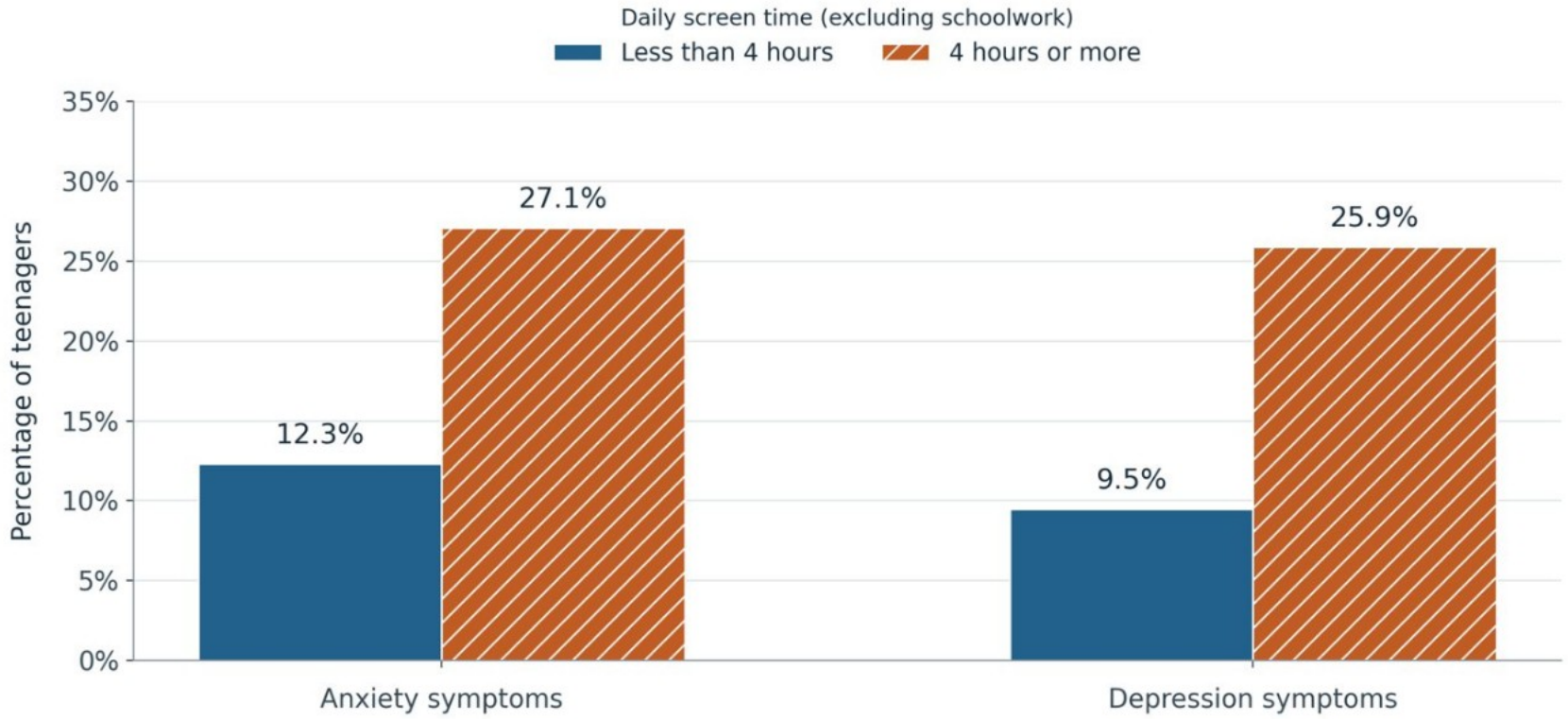
Includes TV, computers, cellphones and other electronic devices; excludes schoolwork.
Percentages total 100.1% because of rounding.

Source: CDC / NCHS, Data Brief 513 (October 2024), National Health Interview Survey–Teen. Table 1.

Use for Graph Detective or the mini-presentation: four moves → so what?

2. Screen time and mental-health symptoms

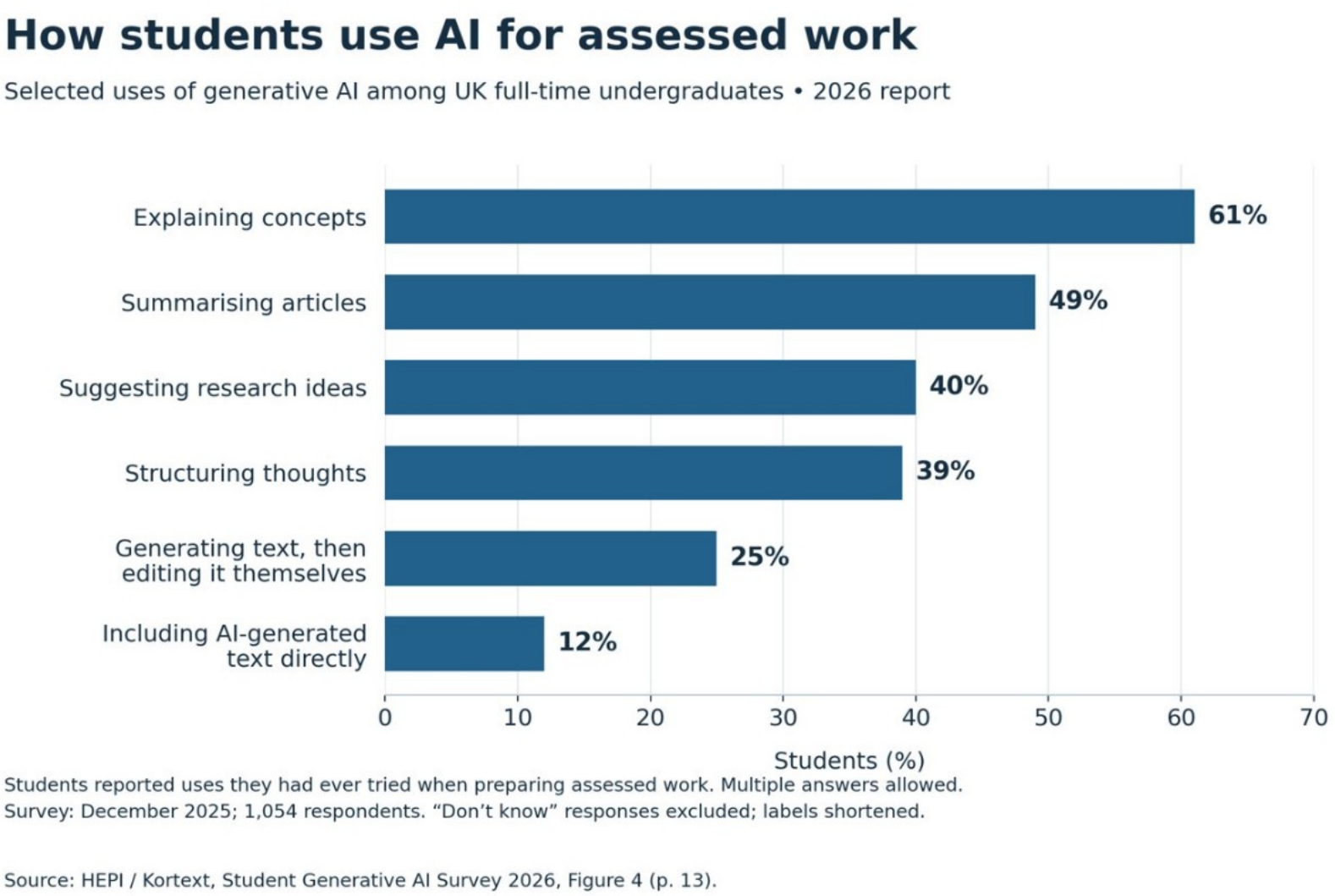
U.S. teenagers aged 12–17 | Survey period: July 2021–December 2023



Symptoms refer to the previous two weeks and were measured using brief screening questionnaires. These are symptoms, not clinical diagnoses. The survey shows an association, not cause and effect. Screen time includes TV, computers, cellphones and other electronic devices.

Source: CDC / NCHS, Data Brief 513 (October 2024), National Health Interview Survey–Teen. Figure 4.

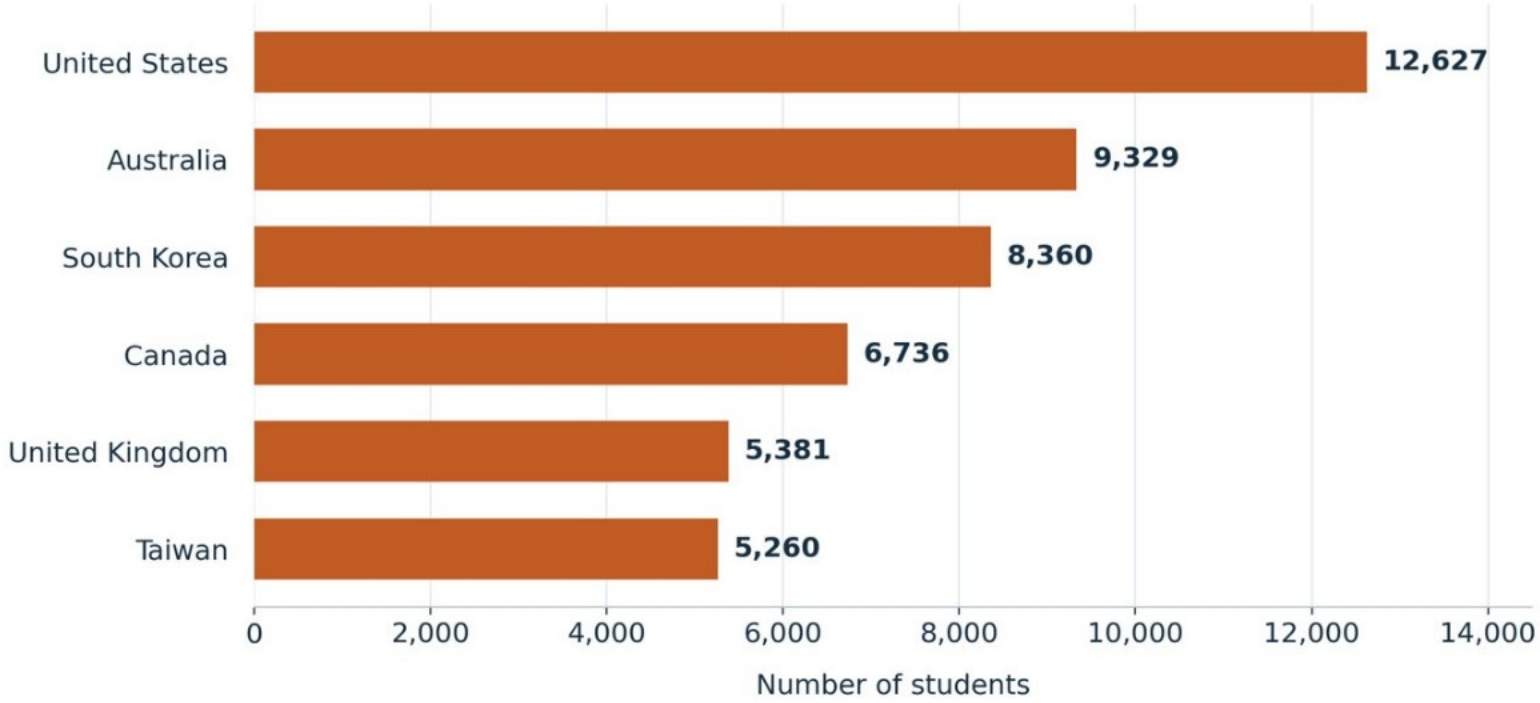
Use for Graph Detective or the mini-presentation: four moves → so what?



Use for Graph Detective or the mini-presentation: four moves → so what?

Top six study-abroad destinations

Japanese students beginning study abroad in academic year 2024



Japanese students enrolled at institutions in Japan who began study abroad during the academic year.
Includes short-term programmes and study with or without institutional exchange agreements.

Source: JASSO, Survey of Japanese Students Studying Abroad, academic year 2024 (published May 2026).

Use for Graph Detective or the mini-presentation: four moves → so what?

CHART POOL D

Average vocabulary test scores over one semester

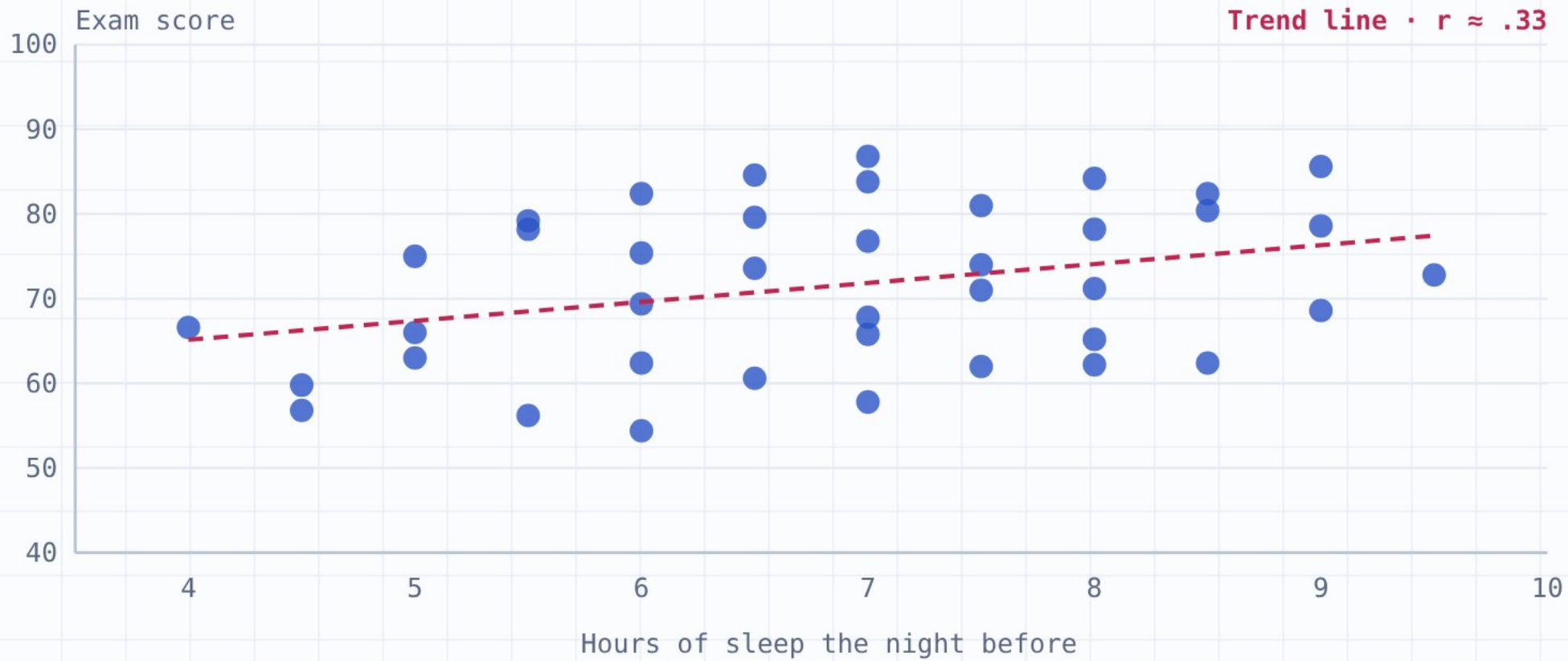


Illustrative data · Two classes, about 30 students each · Score out of 100

Use for Graph Detective or the mini-presentation: four moves → so what?

CHART POOL E

Hours of sleep before an exam and exam score



Illustrative data · One dot = one student, n = 40

Use for Graph Detective or the mini-presentation: four moves → so what?